

Bangladesh

‘Tikka Khan let lose all military weapons as if he were raiding an enemy, not dealing with his own misguided people. The military action was a display of stark cruelty, more merciless than the massacres in Bukhara and Baghdad by Changez Khan and Hulegu Khan, or at Jallianwala Bagh by Gen Dyer. The architects of Operation Searchlight were ironically rewarded for their efforts. Lt Gen Tikka Khan went on to become the chief of army staff, Pakistan, and governor of Punjab; Maj Gen Khadim Hussain Raja was sent as ambassador to Mozambique; and Maj Gen Rao Farman Ali became managing director of Fauji Foundation, Pakistan.’

Lt Gen A.A.K. Niazi

Chief Martial Law Administrator, East Pakistan

‘At the end of the day, it is my view that 1971 is the victory of democracy over military rule. Further, and this is important for soldiers across the world, that it was a victory of humanism over barbarism. The third, and this is where I go back to Lt Gen Sagat Singh, this is where I go back to thinking that this is the victory of manoeuvre over attrition, and last but not the least, a victory of liberation over occupation; the Indian Army went to liberate the Bangladeshis from the genocide that was happening in East Pakistan.’

Lt Gen Shamsheer Singh ‘Shammi’ Mehta

GOCNC Western Command, Indian Army, who was a young major commanding 5 Independent Squadron of 63 Cavalry in East Pakistan in 1971

‘Liberation of Bangladesh sucked in not only its neighbours but became a cause for a superpower conflict and extracted a toll on all the players. George Bush Sr, the US ambassador to the UN, later President of the United States, told Kissinger soon after the fall of Dacca , “Henry I want a transfer when this is over, I want a nice quiet place like Rwanda.”

...

In the words of a later Pakistan National Defence College study of the war, “Indians planned and executed their offensive against East Pakistan in a textbook manner. It was a classic example of thorough planning, minute and meticulous coordination, and bold execution.”

...

Let me just say that for a decisive outcome to this conflict, each service needed time to prepare its human resources and to renew its hardware and material resources. This was the decisive “breathing spell” that Gen (later Field Marshal) Manekshaw obtained by persuading the then Prime Minister Mrs Indira Gandhi to postpone the contemplated military intervention in East Pakistan by nine months. Warfighting requires seamless coordination between the military, diplomatic, and intelligence establishments, and other organs of the state, as well as the support of the people. In 1971, while the political objective was to provide relief to the citizens of East Pakistan, there was also the difficult western front to be taken care of. It turned out to be an actual two-front war with a potential Chinese threat across the Himalayas, a hostile US, and an indifferent, or at best, ambivalent international community. As a consequence, the war understandably was fought under intense pressure to “wrap it up fast”.

Adm Arun Prakash

Chief of Naval Staff (2004–2006), Indian Navy,
and chairman of the Chiefs of Staff Committee

Bangladesh

*Humiliation, Carnage,
Liberation, Chaos*

Iqbal Chand Malhotra

and

Subroto Chattopadhyay

ink | OCCAM

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Preface

I was always intrigued by the left movement of the 1960s and 1970s because it threw up charismatic poster revolutionaries like Ernesto ‘Che’ Guevara; authors like Regis Debray; and filmmakers like Godard, Eisenstein, and Bunuel. To add to this were the many people I listened to at family dinners as a precocious teenager soaking in analyses of the prevailing ‘left wind’ that was unleashed by Indira Gandhi as she battled against the right wing in the Congress and outside. I had the privilege to listen to the likes of Mohan Kumaramangalam, D.P. Dhar, P.C. Joshi, Chandrajit Yadav, Rajni Patel, P.N. Haksar, Mohan Dharia, former prime minister Chandrashekhar, Romesh Chandra, Litto Ghosh, Arjun Arora, and Amrit Nahata over many dinners at my uncle Romesh Thapar’s home in Delhi’s diplomatic enclave and lunches at the offices of the *Seminar* magazine he published. During this period, one witnessed the break-up of Pakistan and the birth of Bangladesh. What intrigued me even more was the Naxalite movement as it absorbed many close friends of my older cousins and some students from my school. My first cousin, the late Raj ‘Dubby’ Bhagat, related memorable anecdotes about the elimination of the Naxals by the Indian Army. He would have known, as his father was the general officer commanding-in-chief (GOC-in-C) of the Indian Army’s central command during this period.

While at Delhi University in the early 1970s, I was heavily influenced by the views of Jayaprakash Narayan and admired his resistance to Mrs Gandhi. I met former prime minister and Congress rebel ideologue Chandrashekhar many times, and the 1977 general elections in India gave me an opportunity to

briefly work for the Janata Party. Soon after the new Janata Party government was sworn in, I moved to the UK to study economics at Cambridge University. The Director of Studies in Economics in my college was Dr Ajit Singh, a Punjabi-Marxian economist, whose PhD thesis was ironically on corporate takeovers! He was a great influence on me. I canvassed for the Labour Party during the 1979 general elections in the UK and thus developed a solid political worldview.

The years rolled by and I evolved into an investigative filmmaker and won over twenty national and international awards; I also wrote five bestsellers on geo-politics. In November 2021, as we emerged from the grip of Covid-19, I was invited by my good friend Lt Gen P.S. Pannu (retd) to speak at a seminar on the fiftieth anniversary of the Bangladesh war held at the United Services Institute in New Delhi. I spoke on a subject that intrigued me, namely, Operation Steeplechase. This was a triple-cordon, black operation sanctioned by the government of India in 1970 to physically eliminate both Indian and Bangladeshi ultra-left-wing cadres using the Indian Army, the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF), and the West Bengal police. Unfortunately, the seminar was not very well attended, and my discourse on Operation Steeplechase was unheard by few, except a person called Subroto Chattopadhyay, the co-author of this book!

Subroto and I got into a conversation about his project to record on film the verbal history of Indian military personnel who fought in the 1971 war for the liberation of Bangladesh. This project was branded Brains Trust and produced by The Peninsula Studios. Subroto and I had many dialogues in 2022 on producing a dramatic reconstruction-based documentary series on the Bangladesh war for an OTT platform. We prepared pitch documents and did the rounds in Mumbai for the best part of 2023. Unfortunately, we hit a wall.

After much soul searching, we decided to first write a book instead and then use the book as a pitching tool to produce an

international OTT series on the war. Meanwhile, there was a regime change in Bangladesh, and it became all the more important to look at the war through the lens of both politics and diplomacy instead of merely focussing on the fighting during the war. The paradox here was the fact that the Punjabi Muslims and Bengali Muslims of British India, who had opted for the new nation of Pakistan because it was to be their collective Muslim homeland, were now fighting to uncouple themselves from this religious union. They purported to join together on the grounds of religion, but could not live together in a democratic framework of pluralistic politics, because they had intense linguistic, cultural, and ethnic differences. Partition and its underlying logic were rapidly being unwound from the spool of political Islam.

My co-author and I both had family roots in the undivided Bengal and Punjab of British India. Subroto's family came from Calcutta and Dacca. My family is a mix of Hindus and Sikhs. My paternal grandparents who were Hindus originally came from the city of Gujrat, located on the western bank of the Chenab River in northern Punjab's Chaj Doab or confluence of the rivers Chenab and Jhelum. My mother's family is Sikh, and my maternal grandparents came from Rawalpindi and Rahimyar Khan, also in the Punjab. Many from my family suffered from the horrors of Partition and had to flee from Muslim persecution and rehabilitate themselves in newly independent India. The story of Partition was very vivid for both of us, but especially me. Though born in independent India, I was, in a sense, a refugee. So, a west Punjabi Hindu and a Bengali were now chronicling a war between the west Punjabi Muslims and the east Bengali Muslims.

What emerged from our research were three relatively unknown facts. First, the unsung heroes of the war of the liberation of Bangladesh were the hundreds of thousands of Bengali guerrillas who fought with grit and determination, but were largely ignored in the official versions of the war written by both India and Pakistan. The second was the confirmation

of the fact that Mrs Gandhi used the Bangladesh crisis as a means to both break up Pakistan and also eliminate the ultra-left movement in both India and East Pakistan. The need to do the latter was to ensure the elimination of all political opposition in East Pakistan, particularly that led by the young Marxist-Leninist firebrand Siraj Sikdar, so as to enable Sheikh Mujibur Rahman's Awami League to sweep the polls clean. The third was the hitherto underplayed fact that because of the liberation war, the world's two nuclear superpowers, the US and the Soviet Union, almost came to kinetic nuclear blows for the first time since the 1962 Cuban missile crisis.

In producer-director Ramesh Sharma's latest feature documentary, *Chronicles of the Forgotten Genocide: The Kissinger Doctrine*, there is a video clip of Admiral Vladimir Kruglyakov, the then commander of the 10th Operative Battle Group of the Soviet Pacific Fleet. Admiral Kruglyakov revealed that the then Soviet Navy's legendary chief Admiral Sergey Gorshkov ordered Kruglyakov to obstruct the US Navy's ten-ship naval task force, Task Force 74, led by the nuclear-powered aircraft carrier USS Enterprise. Task Force 74 was deterred in its tracks by four Whiskey-class Soviet diesel electric submarines equipped with the nuclear-armed P-35 cruise missiles. These submarines reportedly surrounded Task Force 74 in a semicircle from behind and aimed their P-35 missiles at the USS Enterprise. The Soviet P-35 (SS-N-3 Shaddock) missiles were armed with nuclear warheads, specifically a 10-kilotonne nuclear warhead and a larger 200 kilotonne version. Kruglyakov blocked US Navy ships and did not let them through to either Karachi, Chittagong, or Dhaka. A confrontation was averted when the USS Enterprise moved away from the Indian Ocean back towards its original deployment in Southeast Asia.

This development displayed both the true grit exhibited by India and the Soviet Union and the steadfast nature of their alliance.

Other questions remain. Why did Mrs Gandhi believe that Sheikh Mujib was key to the emergence of Bangladesh? Was he in touch with Indian intelligence from 1965 onwards? Did Sheikh Mujib work closely with an Intelligence Bureau (IB) officer named Phanindra Nath Banerjee? Could Banerjee have confidentially been in contact with Sheikh Mujib through another IB officer called P.N. Ojha who was based in Dacca from 1965 onwards? Could Ojha have been Banerjee's cover identity?

Intrigued or scandalized?

Please read on.

Iqbal Chand Malhotra
New Delhi, September 2025

Section I

Turmoil in Coupling

by

Iqbal Chand Malhotra

1

Radcliffe's Unfortunate Legacy

Sometime in the middle of July 1947, Wg Cdr Bryant Fenner of the Royal Indian Air Force's (RIAF) Communication Squadron (India) looked out of the cockpit window of his Douglas C-47 Dakota in the direction of the landing strip at Calcutta's Dum Dum Aerodrome. It was noon and the outside temperature was 91 F.¹ He had been flying nonstop since 07:30 hrs IST after taking off from RAF Willingdon, also known as Safdarjung Aerodrome in New Delhi. The Dakota had a cruising speed of 333 km/hour and a range of 2,400 km. It had revolutionized air transport in the 1930s and 1940s. Fenner had an extraordinary passenger on board.

The passenger was Sir Cyril Radcliffe, who was flying to Calcutta as the head of the Bengal Boundary Commission. Radcliffe was one of London's top civil lawyers and had been educated at Haileybury College and at New College, Oxford. He did law from the Inner Temple and practised at the Chancery Bar. Thereafter, during WWII, Radcliffe was director general at the Ministry of Information, working closely with Brendan Bracken, an acolyte of Prime Minister Winston Churchill. Lord Listowel, the then secretary of state for India, had zeroed on Radcliffe as his choice of a man of integrity, who without bias could head both the boundary commissions for the provinces of Punjab and Bengal, which were to be partitioned along communal lines in the run-up to the independence of India on 15 August 1947 after 190 years of British rule.

Both provinces had been mired in vicious communal violence over the last year. Radcliffe's brief was to partition them, so that the British could leave India as soon as was practically possible. This was a monumental task for Radcliffe as he had neither been to India nor did he know much about the country. Even the advertisements that appeared in London's most famous newspaper *The Times* that encouraged those travelling to the tropics to drop by Victoria Street's *Army and Navy Stores* to pick up some tropical clothing left him unmoved. Radcliffe flew to India with his stiff detachable collared shirts from Jermyn Street and his Palm Beach Saville Row suits that, despite their lighter fabric, were hardly a concession to India's monsoon-induced humidity and must have been suffocating and oppressive to wear. Because there was no room air-conditioning in those days, his formal suits probably discouraged him from going outdoors, except when very necessary. It can be argued that if Radcliffe's own apparently reserved personality had not been further encumbered by his inappropriate sartorial innocence, curiosity might have led him astray on the first evening of his arrival in Calcutta to experience the ambience of a *mujra* at one of the classy establishments in Sonagachi, Calcutta's red-light area. He might also then have deigned to get a brief introduction to Bengal's sophisticated cosmopolitan culture, literature, and aesthetics. He could have also visited the Kalighat Kali Temple, the Armenian Holy Church of Nazareth, the Victoria Memorial, and Chinatown.



Cyril Radcliffe

After his whistle-stop visits to Lahore and Calcutta to meet the members of the two boundary commissions, Radcliffe settled into the Controller's House on the edge of the vice regal estate atop New Delhi's Raisina Hill. However, because of the extremely tight deadline of 15 August 1947 set by Viceroy Lord Mountbatten as

the date for independence, Radcliffe did not have enough time to sit with any of the commissions. Therefore, the reports and records of their proceedings and all the material submitted to them by counsel representing the Congress, the Muslim League, Sikh members of the Punjab Legislative Assembly, and other interested parties were flown to him in New Delhi each day. In this way, through July and into mid-August, Radcliffe burnt the midnight oil in the bungalow allotted to him, suffering terribly in the trauma of the monsoon. More than anything he achieved during this time was his ability to physically survive his term as the chairman of the Boundary Commission.

The end of WWII and the impending political uncertainty unleashed by the new Clement Atlee government in the UK to grant independence to India and partition the country transformed the ground reality in the Bengal Presidency. Communal politics emerged as the frontrunner, leaving sanity far behind. The atmosphere was highly surcharged in Calcutta. On 16 August 1946, Muslim League rioters ravaged Calcutta for forty-eight hours. Following this wave of mayhem, a combined force of Hindus and Sikhs retaliated with even more vengeance.

For Radcliffe, therefore, there were no easy answers. In the densely populated Bengal Presidency, any line that he drew to partition it was bound to cut through road and rail communications, irrigation schemes, electric power systems, and even individual landholdings. The Bengal commission was also responsible for the Sylhet district and other Muslim-majority areas in Assam, and for the hill tracts around Chittagong, which were inhabited by Buddhist hill tribes. How were these areas to be dealt with? But the million-dollar question was: who should get Calcutta? If deprived of Calcutta, Muslim East Bengal would almost certainly decline into a rural slum. But could Calcutta itself survive without its mofussil areas and the river systems which flowed through the contiguous Muslim-inhabited countryside? Within the city, Muslims were only a quarter of

the population. The argument, therefore, was that it seemed correct for Calcutta to go to India. But here was the paradox. A large proportion of the Hindu population within the city were Scheduled Castes, who supported the Muslim League against the Congress. Radcliffe was truly outfoxed.

The communal divide in Calcutta was so vicious that even the hitherto 'impartial' British administration could not decide who lit the first spark on that fateful August morning. According to the Congress Working Committee, first blood was drawn by Muslims carrying bamboo sticks, swords, and axes, which they brandished before unarmed Hindus. However, the Bengal Muslim League's working committee found that 'peaceful Muslim processions almost everywhere had to face a barrage of brickbats, stones, and missiles'.² Photographs of the events that transpired that day appeared in *The Modern Review* (Calcutta) where the photo spread showed Muslim aggressors and concluded that the riots started when 'their Fuehrer had declared a Jihad, and thousands of gangsters had been imported to reinforce them'.³



*Huseyn Shaheed
Suhrawardy*

The violence unleashed in Calcutta continued to simmer, and as 1946 ended, it was evident that the British disengagement from their hitherto firm administration of the Bengal Presidency was becoming clear. Nobody was in effective control.⁴ Calcutta's agony in the year after the Great Killing is indescribable. Fear, hatred, and vengeance had permeated into the entire fabric of the city. The bubbling cauldron of hate once again overflowed, and Calcutta's first major riot of the year occurred in late March 1947. A further mosaic of stray incidents coalesced into large-scale mob violence and troops were called in to restore order.⁵ The chronic rioting

became a part and parcel of life and symbolically resembled a stream, which ebbed and flowed, but never ceased for more than a few days.⁶ The government had clearly lost control, even though the Muslim League Prime Minister Huseyn Shaheed Suhrawardy now began to take a lot of precautions.⁷ The once effective Calcutta police had itself become undermined and demoralized by communalism, and the Hindu majority regarded the Muslim League government with intense suspicion. The slide in lawlessness made the public realize that their only neutral protector was now the Indian Army. In fact, a week after ordering the setting up of the Punjab Boundary Force days after Radcliffe's arrival in India, Mountbatten paid a visit to Calcutta, where Suhrawardy took the opportunity of making a last plea to be allowed to form an independent Bengal. This was Suhrawardy trying to climb a mountain walking backwards uphill in the mist! Though Calcutta was relatively peaceful, it was edgy and uneasy. Mountbatten asked Lt Gen Sir Francis Tucker, the GOC of the Eastern Army Command, if he, too, would like a special boundary force. Tucker declined the offer. Tucker was already organized, and could handle the situation with the existing troops under his command, even though they were far fewer than 50,000. Most importantly, the population of Calcutta reposed their faith in the occupant of Fort William as their unbiased protector.

It was this supercharged atmosphere of mistrust, fear, and violent communal hatred that hit Radcliffe that fateful day in July 1947 when he drove from Dum Dum Airport to Government House in Calcutta. The line that Radcliffe was to draw later that day would split the Bengal Presidency which had historically always been a single economic, cultural, and ethnic (Bengali-Hindu or Bengali-Muslim) zone into two halves. Both halves were intricately connected. East Bengal produced food and raw materials which West Bengal consumed, and the industrialized

West produced manufactured goods which were consumed by the East. Depending on the way one looked at it, this was either considered an exploitative or a mutually beneficial trade and exchange. This trade would, however, be severely disrupted by Partition. Rail, road, and water communication routes would be severed between them and would have disastrous economic consequences.

Jute was the largest industry in Bengal at Partition. The Radcliffe Line left every single jute mill in West Bengal but four-fifths of the jute-producing land in East Bengal. The superior varieties of jute were cultivated mostly in East Bengal. While West Bengal's mills would face an acute shortage of raw material, and the industry would be plunged into a crisis, jute farmers in East Bengal would now be left without a market for their produce. Post-Partition, the legal export of jute to West Bengal would suddenly become an anti-national act for a Pakistani exporter and the smuggling of raw jute would increase across the border. Nevertheless, the savvy new Marwari owners of the former British-owned jute mills in West Bengal rapidly increased contract jute production from local farmers, and in the mid- to late 1950s became largely self-sufficient in jute. West Bengal's mills became less dependent on East Bengal for raw materials in the post-Partition years.

Similar problems would hit West Bengal's paper and leather industries. The paper mills used East Bengal's bamboo while the tanneries consumed leather, which was also mainly produced there. Like jute, the lack of raw material pushed both industries into decline and unemployment became rampant. Furthermore, all the rice-producing districts would go to East Bengal, causing severe food shortages in West Bengal. These shortages continued into the 1950s and 1960s and were, in no small measure, responsible for the growth of far-left political movements in both parts of the partitioned state.

The Radcliffe Line was to leave East Bengal devoid of large industry. There were few mineral resources in this region. Its economy was completely agrarian. Calcutta was the centre of Bengal's economic and social development for both Hindus and Muslims. All the large industries, military bases, government offices, and most institutions of higher education were based in and around Calcutta. Without this city, East Bengal was decapitated. It lost its traditional market for agricultural products, the most important port of India as well as the entire erstwhile Bengal Presidency. East Bengal had to begin from scratch. Dacca was then only a district headquarters. Government offices had to be placed inside makeshift buildings. Dacca also faced a severe human resource crisis. Most of the bureaucracy in East Bengal were Hindu and migrated to West Bengal. Often, the posts had to be filled up by West Pakistani officers. Desperately poor, East Bengal soon became politically dominated by West Pakistan. Economic disparities and subjugation of Bengalis by the Punjabi elite eventually led to a struggle for separation in 1971.